

Trigonometry

MATH 123 Fall 2026

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Chapter 1

Course Syllabus

1.1 TL;DR

- *This course is not graded the way you are used to!* Read [Assessment](#), particularly [Introduction to Ungrading](#) and [Culminating Experience](#). Also check the [Important Dates](#)!
- Make sure to read [Course Policies and Expectations](#), in particular pay attention to [Getting More from Class](#).
- Review [Classroom and Campus Safety](#) and [Safety Information Locations](#).

This document is intended to give you the basics of what you need to know to succeed in this course, including not only details of [Content](#), and [Course Policies and Expectations](#), but also the guiding principles behind how I approach teaching, and teaching this course in particular.

I reserve the right to adjust this document as needed and will notify you of any changes through Blackboard.

1.2 Instructor and Course Information

1.2.1 Prerequisites

MTH 122.

1.2.2 Meeting Times

Section 11	Tuesday and Thursday 4:00– 5:15, MAK D1-117
Section 14	Tuesday and Thursday 11:30–12:45, MAK D2-329
Individual Meetings	Scheduled Separately, MAK A2-110 or via Zoom

1.2.3 Contact Information

Table 1 Instructor and Department Information

Item	Value
Instructor	Dr. Clark Wells
Office Location	MAK Room A2-110 MAK
Office Phone Number	(616) 331-2444
Email	wellsc@gvsu.edu
Department Office Location	Room A2-178 MAK
Department Phone Number	(616) 331-2040
Math Tutoring Center	Room A2-601 MAK

Table 2 Student Hours

Day	Time	Location
Tuesday	2:00–2:50	MAK A2-110
Thursday	2:00–2:50	MAK A2-601 (Math Tutoring Center)

Student Hours are subject to change upon discussion with class members.

1.2.4 Withdrawal Date, Safety, and Accommodation

1.2.4.1 Withdrawal Date

The deadline for withdrawing with a ‘W’ grade is November 7 at 5:00 PM and is the responsibility of the student.

1.2.4.2 Accessibility, and Accommodation

If you need accommodations due to a learning, physical, or other disability you must present a memo to me from [Student Accessibility Resources \(SAR\)](#) indicating the existence of a disability and the suggested reasonable accommodations. If you have not already done so, please contact the Student Accessibility Resource (215 The Blue Connection), by calling 331-2490 or emailing access@gvsu.edu. Please note that I am unable to provide accommodations based upon disability until I have received a copy of the SAR issued memo. For more information visit gvsu.edu/accessibility.

Growth as a person does is certainly not limited to the classroom or academics. If there is an upcoming faith or religious observance that could have an impact on your attendance or work in the class, please [submit a request](#) during the first two weeks of the semester, or as soon as is reasonably possible, so that we can plan together accordingly.

1.2.4.3 Classroom and Campus Safety

I consider classroom and campus safety our shared responsibility. Please familiarize yourself with the classroom emergency placard, which contains important information that could prove useful should an emergency arise. Emergency situations could include a fire alarm, tornado warning, medical emergency, or hostile intruder, and our response might consist of evacuating the building in an orderly manner, moving as a group to a different location in the building, rendering assistance a class member, or staying put and locking the classroom door. In all cases, I will provide clear instructions as to what you should do.

Please make sure to have your primary mobile number listed in Banner so that you will automatically receive any campus alerts. Should you receive an emergency notification in class, notify me immediately.

You can find more information about campus safety can be found at the sites shown in [Table 3](#).

Table 3 Safety Information Locations

Information	Resource Location
Directions for enabling additional contact means to the campus alert system	https://www.gvsu.edu/gvsualert
List of campus tornado safety locations	https://www.gvsu.edu/emergency/tornado-safety-location-2.htm
Active shooter response	https://www.gvsu.edu/dps/active-shooter-response-85.htm
Medical emergencies and campus AED locations	https://www.gvsu.edu/emergency/medical-emergency-15.htm

1.3 Introduction and Teaching Philosophy

1.3.1 Introduction to Math 123

1.3.1.1 Introduction

Trigonometry, Math 123 is designed to give you tools to succeed in various programs in science, such as health professions, geology, and biology.

1.3.1.2 Course Description

Math 123 is a study of oscillatory behavior, circular functions, and their applications. In order to understand these things, it is important to see where they arise. This means analyzing data or situations, choosing among appropriate

models, and solving applied problems. Of course, we can't predict every situation you will encounter in your future, so it is also important to develop flexibility and resilience.

More information can be found in [Content](#) and [Objectives](#).

1.3.2 Teaching Philosophy

1.3.2.1 Learning is fun!

Learning is about feeding our curiosity, stretching ourselves to be better, finding out, and understanding. Those things are all rewarding, which is another word for *fun*. When learning isn't fun, there is something badly wrong.

You know what isn't fun? Grades. Getting them, assigning them, working for them — none of these things are fun. They are, in many ways, the *opposite* of fun.

A growing body of evidence shows essentially no correlation between grades and success in future endeavors. Anecdotal evidence and educational research support the idea that grades, in fact, create a *dis-incentive* for learning and create incentives for several negative behaviors, including engaging in academic dishonesty ("cheating"). Neuroscience research further shows that dopamine is critical for learning, except in the case of learning with punishment. In other words, *you need fun to learn*. See, for example, elcencia.com/iamapirate/dopamine.pdf

One thing we will do in this course is remove the pressure of the grade using a version of specifications grading that is sometimes called *ungrading*. More details are in [Assessment](#).

1.3.2.2 Math is fun!

Many of you may have an experience of mathematics that does not suggest math is fun. Even if you know and appreciate the *usefulness* of math, the subject is often presented in a way that sucks all the fun out of it. Imagine sitting down to play a video game and finding that before you can actually start playing the game, you must first spend hours and hours memorizing cheat codes! "Now we need to master the *up, up, down, down, left, right, left, right, B, A, Start* sequence and its variations. This will make later games easier. Enter this sequence 35 times on the next screen."

This is nothing like what mathematics really is. Yes, sometimes memorizing techniques can make later things easier, but these techniques have deeper meanings and origins. They are not just a random sequence of buttons to push.

Instead, mathematics is about analyzing situations, carefully describing or quantifying them, and looking for (more or less universal) patterns. That may still sound dry, but my personal goal in this class, in addition to giving you useful techniques, is to help you to see the beauty and joy of mathematics.

1.4 Objectives and Content

1.4.1 Content

1.4.1.1 Topics

- Circular functions
- Vectors
- Complex numbers
- Polar Coordinates
- Graphing sinusoidal functions
- Inverse trigonometric functions
- Recognizing and applying trigonometric identities
- Solving equations involving trigonometric functions
- Solving triangles

1.4.1.2 Additional Content

In addition to developing mathematical tools, techniques, and skills, we will seek to further our understanding of the role and importance of mathematics as a not only a tool, but as a field of human endeavor. We will explore how various concepts have developed and evolved, and how various mathematical models are interrelated.

1.4.2 Objectives

The syllabus of record for MTH 123 states:

After successful completion of the course, students will be able to

1. Explain the definition of the circular functions.
2. Compute the circular functions exactly for common functions.
3. Graph sinusoidal functions and determine their equations.
4. Explain the definition of the inverse trigonometric functions.
5. Perform computations of inverse trigonometric functions.
6. Apply trigonometric identities to computations of trigonometric functions.
7. Solve equations involving trigonometric functions.
8. Solve application problems using trigonometric functions.

Furthermore, Grand Valley State University's mission statement is: "At Grand Valley State University, we empower learners in their pursuits, professions, and purpose. The university enriches society through excellent teaching, active scholarship, advancement of equity, and public service."

This course is a step along the way to you achieving your own professional and personal goals. In light of this, some of my goals for this course are for you

- to develop the skill of thinking mathematically,
- to have a stronger idea of how trigonometry relates to future classes and to the physical world, and
- to have an idea of what mathematics actually is.

1.4.3 Materials and Resources

1.4.3.1 Primary Reference

The main text for this course will be [Trigonometry](#) by Ted Sundstrom and Steven Schlicker. This PDF is a free, open educational resource.

1.4.3.2 Additional Materials

We will also use [Trigonometry](#) by Katherine Yoshiwara. This is an online, free, open educational resource.

Any required supplementary material used will be put placed on BlackBoard, on reserve in the library, or otherwise made available to you.

1.5 Important Dates

Aug. 31	Classes Begin
Sep. 4	100% Tuition Refund Deadline (before 5:00pm)
Sep. 4	Last Day to Add, Register, or Pay (before 5:00pm)
Sep. 7	Labor Day (No Classes)
Sep. 25	Credit/No Credit Deadline (before 5:00pm)
Sep. 25	75% Tuition Refund Deadline (before 5:00pm)

Sep. 8–18	<i>Goal Setting Meeting</i>
Sep. 29	<i>Progress Check 1</i>
Oct. 12–16	Mid-term Evaluations
Oct. 13	<i>Progress Check 2</i>
Oct. 22	Mid-term Grades Available to Students
Oct. 25–27	Fall Break
Oct. 30–Nov. 12	<i>Progress Meeting</i>
Nov. 13	Withdraw with a ‘W’Grade (before 5:00pm)
Nov. 25–29	Thanksgiving Day recess
Nov. 16–20	<i>Progress Check 3</i>
Dec. 12	Classes End and Commencement
Dec. 12–19	Examination Week
Dec. 14–18	<i>Final Meetings</i>
Dec. 19	Semester Ends
Dec. 22	Grades Due
Dec. 24	Grades Available to Students

Chapter 2

Course Documents

2.1 Assessment

2.1.1 Introduction to Ungrading

As mentioned earlier, substantial evidence shows that grades and grading are inherently antithetical to learning. *Ungrading* shifts the goal of a course from achievement to learning.

It is also important to note that the content of this course focuses on developing conceptual and procedural fluency with a set of concepts and tools as well as developing a “mathematical mindset”. Thus, it makes sense to have learning targets that students need to satisfy in order to consider the course successful.

Ultimately, though, this is your course. It is you who are the learner, and so you are in the best position to determine what will be of the most interest, what will be the most engaging, and, beyond the basics, what will be of the most value to you. More than that, *you* are the best person to determine how much you have learned. Therefore, you will be an active participant in determining the direction of the course and in your evaluation.

To put things bluntly, I will determine, based on a set of learning targets and a body of evidence that you present to me, whether you have done the work necessary to pass the class. Beyond that, *you* will determine your own grade, based on the evidence you present that you have met your own goals, as outlined in [Portfolio and Reader’s Guide](#).

2.1.2 Portfolio and Reader’s Guide

During the first week of class, we will discuss as a class what success in this class might look like, and then you will meet individually with me to develop a set of personalized goals. (See [Important Dates](#).)

These goals will not about grades and grading. Instead, you are invited to consider your *learning*, and more generally what *success* in this course will be for you.

Over the course of the semester, you will assemble a comprehensive portfolio that demonstrates that you have met the basic requirements for the course and demonstrates your progress toward your goals. Part of this portfolio will be three *Progress Checks*.

In addition to the Progress Checks, you are expected to regularly submit items to me for focused feedback. Based on this feedback, you will reflect, rework, extend, and revise as necessary to meet basic requirements and show forward progress.

At least one time, mid-semester, you will schedule an individual meeting to discuss your progress, your successes, and any challenges you are facing.

For each individual meeting, you will prepare and share with me an agenda or guide ahead of time with specific items you wish to discuss. This guide should discuss successes, challenges, and progress, and should direct the reader where to find evidence of these items. For example, you might include something along the lines of “*Successes* Since our last meeting, I have reviewed and improved my understanding of difference quotients and average rate of change. Some good examples of my understanding and interpretation can be found in *Driving North/South* and *Filling a Tank*.”¹

Your guide should also address the following questions.

- What are you particularly proud of or excited about?
- What has been challenging?

¹These titles are completely invented and may not be anything like the titles of activities we actually use.

- What do you plan to do next?, and
- What do you need from me (the instructor) to facilitate your progress toward your goals?

For your final portfolio conference, which will be during the week of final exams, you will submit your final portfolio (with a final version of your reader's guide), again citing items of interest. Then, based on your learning and progress toward your goals and your submitted evidence, you will tell me what grade you have earned for the course.

2.1.3 Required Elements of the Portfolio

The following items are required to be in your portfolio.

2.1.3.1 Reader's Guide and Progress Report

Depending on how you choose to organize your portfolio, this could simply be a table of contents plus a brief discussion of your progress.

For each submission of your portfolio, you will update your report to discuss your overall progress, to highlight progress since the last check-in, and to cite specific items of interest. This will also include a discussion of progress on your group project and of group dynamics.

The goal of this is to help the reader (your instructor) prepare for the meeting with you and to make items easy to find. One way to think of this is to think of answering the questions,

- What are you particularly proud of or excited about?
- What has been challenging?
- What progress have you made on the group project?
- How has your group been sharing responsibilities?
- What do you plan to do next?, and
- What do you need from me, the instructor, to facilitate your progress toward your goals?

2.1.3.2 Progress Checks

Several times throughout the semester, we will have in-class progress checks. These are opportunities for you to show your understanding of concepts and fluency with calculations.

When your progress checks are returned to you, you are expected to put them in your portfolio and write a reflection on your performance, noting things that went well as well as areas of future growth.

If there were substantial errors or misconceptions, those should also be addressed in the reflection.

2.1.3.3 Catalog of Detailed Examples

Over the course of the semester we will be studying functions and their derivatives from graphical, analytic, numerical, and conceptual viewpoints. For each topic, whenever possible, you must include at least one detailed example of the use of that concept in a practical setting. That is, each example must:

- Begin with a practical situation where the numbers have units and meaning.
- Include a discussion of why the particular concept or tool was used (possibly including why other approaches would not be appropriate).
- Show the process of using the concept to understand and solve the problem.
- Include multiple representations, such as graphical, numerical, and algebraic representations.
- Interpret the solution in context, giving a result with practical implications.

2.1.3.4 Overviews of Activities, Techniques, and Applications

Over the course of the semester you will be assigned multiple activities, investigations, and projects dealing with techniques, concepts, and applications of calculus.

For each *topic* we study, not each activity, you are expected to demonstrate understanding of the main mathematical ideas and an ability to apply any associated techniques.

Like everything in the portfolio, these are works in progress, and you are expected to revisit them in light of later activities or readings that may change your understanding of them.

2.1.3.5 Citation of Sources

If you make use of any outside resources for this class, you are required to cite those sources. The particular format of citations is not important. If you need specificity, please follow MLA standards.

2.1.4 Optional Elements of the Portfolio

You can (and are encouraged to) include any items in your portfolio that demonstrate progress toward your individual goals. The following items are some things that previous students have chosen to include.

2.1.4.1 Details of Activities and Investigations

In addition to the basics for an activity, you may choose to include more.

For instance, you might include work to show that you have:

- gained additional depth of understanding of important concepts
- understood the historical or philosophical importance of a topic (existence of solutions versus calculation of solutions), or
- made connections to other topics in this course, in other courses, your major, or to everyday life.

2.1.4.2 Experiments and Explorations

If there is a topic from class that you feel does not go far enough, you are free to investigate more deeply. For example, if you particularly enjoy global optimization, you might look at a more complex optimization, such as minimizing the construction cost for an oil barrel.

2.1.4.3 Summaries of Outside Reading

If you use outside sources to guide your learning, you may want to include more than just citations. You can summarize what you learned from those sources and include the summaries.

2.1.4.4 Other Items

Other items may be included in your Portfolio if you they demonstrate your progress in meeting your course goals. Some examples of what you may choose to include are practice problems, conjectures, or expository papers.

2.1.5 Professionalism

For this course, I define professionalism to mean respect for yourself, your classmates, and your instructor. This includes (but is not limited to)

- consistent forward progress and timely completion of assignments,
- prompt scheduling of and on-time arrival for individual meetings,
- preparation for class, and
- attendance and participation in class.

A pattern of unprofessional behavior during the semester may, at my discretion, result in a course grade penalty of up to two full letter grades (20%).

2.1.6 Culminating Experience

There will be no final exam in this course. Instead, your individual conference with me during the final period will serve as the culminating experience in this course.

2.2 Course Policies and Expectations

This course is subject to the GVSU policies listed at <http://www.gvsu.edu/coursepolicies/>. The following policies also apply.

2.2.1 Use of Generative AI

Use of Generative AI Large Language Models [LLMs] (such as ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, etc.) in this class is subject to a few conditions, namely [Awareness](#), [Transparency](#), and [Accountability](#). Transparency and accountability are fairly straight-forward, and are closely related to [Academic Integrity](#), but awareness is both more subtle and arguably more important.

2.2.1.1 Awareness

If you plan to use generative AI in this class, be aware of what you are using it for and whether it helps you toward your goals or just wastes your time. I find a useful analogy to be the idea of *taking a forklift to the gym*.

If your goal in going to the gym is to strengthen your muscles by lifting weights, using a forklift to lift the weights defeats the purpose. Sure, you can get in your reps, you can “lift” more than you could without the forklift, and you can do more reps and not get tired, but it doesn’t work toward your goal of strengthening your muscles. It is a waste of your time. Worse, it gets in other people’s way as they try to reach their strength training goals.

On the other hand, maybe you went to the gym because you work there and the boss wants you to move several large, heavy machines from one part of the building to another. If that’s the case, using the forklift makes a lot of sense, because it is in fact helping with your goal of moving the machines.

Education is about strengthening your mental muscles. Be aware of how the use of heavy machinery either helps or hinders your progress.

Awareness also includes awareness of the ethical and practical pitfalls involved in using generative AI. You should be aware that

- AI is trained on the works of other people
- Plausibility, not objective truth, is the training goal of AI. It often makes things up that sound plausible.
- AI is resource intensive. For example, according to what-uses-more.com, a paragraph of AI generated text uses more than 23 times as much electricity and water than a Google search without AI.

2.2.1.2 Transparency

When you use generative AI, be transparent: make note of exactly what you asked the AI to do (your prompts), and exactly what part of the AI results you used in your materials. For example, you might include something like the following in your portfolio.

“In this problem, we were asked to model the number of hours of daylight as a function of the date. I knew this would be either sine or cosine, but I still didn’t understand how to make the right days line up with the peaks and valleys, so I asked Copilot to explain. My prompt was ‘Explain how to shift a sine function so that the peaks and valleys line up with data.’”

“Copilot started by giving a formula for a sine function as $y = A \sin(B(x - C)) + D$ and then gave step-by-step alignment guide. The important part for me was how to adjust the ‘phase shift’, C . It said to ‘Find where a peak (or valley) occurs in your data, and shift the sine wave so its peak matches that point: $C = x$ -value of desired peak.’ I was then able to align the peak amount of sunlight with June 21 by using $C = 172$ days since the beginning of the year.”

2.2.1.3 Accountability

When you use generative AI, you are accountable. What that means is that you must be able to explain all of your work and understand the power and the limitations of using LLMs.

Using the example of fitting a sine wave, a student submitting this should have noticed that *Copilot got it wrong*. Setting $C = 172$ places the *midline* of the sine function at $x = 172$ days. Using $C = 172$ in the formula $y = A \cos(B(x - C)) + D$ would place the peak at $x = 172$, or you could find the date of the spring equinox and set C to that value in $y = A \sin(B(x - C)) + D$.

2.2.2 Initial Drafts of Work in Timed Settings

Initial drafts of work done in class (a setting with limited time) are not expected to be typeset. Instead, high resolution images or digital scans of your initial work can be included in your portfolio.

Reflections on your work, revisions, and corrections, though, are expected to follow the guidelines given for work in un-timed settings.

2.2.3 Submitting Un-Timed Work for Feedback

2.2.3.1 Format of Submissions

All drafts of work done in settings without prescribed time constraints, such as exercises, proofs, expository writing, and so forth,

- must be written using the software capable of high-quality mathematical typesetting or neatly hand-written and scanned;
- must be spell-checked and proofread for grammatical correctness;
- must be submitted electronically, via BlackBoard or shared link; and
- must be available in a form suitable for commenting and editing.

See [Mathematical Typesetting](#), for more information about options for mathematical typesetting software.

2.2.3.2 FERPA and Email

Please note that due to security issues and based on guidance from the Department of Education regarding FERPA, the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act of 1974, I cannot use e-mail or any unsecured platform to discuss grades.

2.2.4 Time Management

One of my goals for this course is to challenge you to grow intellectually while giving you the tools and environment that will allow you to succeed. If you at any time feel that you are not being challenged to achieve your fullest potential in understanding the concepts we address, or if you have comments about the pace of the class or any other concerns, I encourage you to discuss your concerns with me during my [student hours](#) or an appointment with me.

As a university mathematics course, you should expect the course to be challenging. While we will all work to make time spent in class as productive as possible, it is not possible to learn everything using class time alone: much of your learning and understanding will occur as you reflect on what we have done in class, work on problems, and read and discuss course material outside of class.

The most important rule for this course is *do not get behind in your work*. Using a portfolio removes the inherent penalties in a slow start, but the trade off is that it can be tempting to put things off until later. Always stay up to date with the material in this course. Make succeeding in this course a priority!

2.2.5 Getting More from Class

Learning cannot take place solely in the classroom, and you should expect to put in considerable work outside of class. Different students learn in different ways and require different types of support. I am committed to providing you with the support that you require, whether that means being a critical questioner of your processes and results, providing guidance and mentoring, or something else entirely.

This section has some advice and perspectives that I hope will help you make the most of your time and effort in this class.

2.2.5.1 Attend Student Hours

First, never hesitate to come to me during [student hours](#) or to make an appointment to see me. My primary job is to facilitate your understanding and learning, so when you come to me you are allowing me to do my job well.

2.2.5.2 Form a Study Group

You may also find that working with a group of classmates is beneficial. I encourage you to form groups to work together outside of class. Working with a group also allows you to see things from different perspectives.

If you or your study group have questions, please come to me and we will work through them together. If my [student hours](#) are at times that you cannot make due to other commitments, [make an appointment](#) to see me at another time.

2.2.5.3 Make Attendance a Priority

As discussed in [Assessment](#), attendance in class is an important part of this course. You are expected to be present and on time each day we meet. You are responsible for announcements made in class concerning material covered, assignments, changes in the syllabus or due dates, or anything else pertinent to the course. Furthermore, many of the activities from class and reflections on class will become part of your portfolio.

Nevertheless, your health and safety and that of your classmates is important. Therefore *if you are ill, stay at home*. In the event of a University recognized absence, arrangements can be made for you to mitigate the effects of missing class.

2.2.5.4 Come to Class Prepared

It is imperative that you work on a consistent basis. This applies to both the day-to-day work to prepare for class as well as the more long-term work such as the portfolio.

You should keep a well-organized record of your study notes, completed problems, and problems in progress for future reference. Note that these are acceptable as part of your portfolio if you believe they help make your case!

You must understand that a great deal of your learning in this course must occur on your own. It is your responsibility to complete assigned reading, read assignments carefully, complete the problems, be prepared for class, and to seek support as needed.

2.2.5.5 Participate in Class

For many people, their experience has taught them that asking questions or questioning results is frowned on as either disrespectful or inattentive. In this class, I want to cultivate an atmosphere where questioning processes, results, and reasoning is seen as showing respect that the other person's ideas are worth thinking about. This type of respectful questioning (including questioning your own processes, thoughts, and results) is crucial to becoming an effective and flexible thinker.

Asking and answering questions are not the only ways, or even the best ways, to participate in class. While we may think of class participation in terms of speaking up in class, participation can take many forms, such as active listening in groups, writing up or journaling individual or group assignments, drawing graphs or creating visual representations, sharing strategies, questioning results, and many others. In every class meeting, there will be ample opportunity for you to actively participate.

2.2.5.6 Make Full Use of Additional Learning Resources

The idea of “asking for help” can sometimes take on a negative connotation. I prefer to think of it as one way to make use of all of your available resources. If you need to travel from the Allendale campus to the Grand Rapids, you probably don't think that taking the Laker Line instead driving a car is a bad thing, it's simply another effective way to travel. And there are also lots of reasons why some students might not have access to a car, including having a flat tire or not having a license. In a similar way, there are lots of reasons to seek out additional learning resources.

In addition to student hours and individual meetings with me, GVSU provides a variety of tutoring resources, including the [Math Center](#) (located in Mackinac Hall). More information about other tutoring services can be found on the [GVSU Tutoring](#) website.

Using these resources is *smart*, and can be beneficial to every student.

2.2.6 Academic Integrity

2.2.6.1 Integrity of Scholarship and Grades

Truth and honesty: The principles of truth and honesty are recognized as fundamental to a community of teachers and scholars. The university expects that both faculty members and students will honor these principles and in so doing protect the validity of university grades. This means that all academic work will be done by the student to whom it is assigned without unauthorized aid of any kind. Instructors, for their part, will exercise care in the planning and supervision of academic work, so that honest effort will be positively encouraged. Compliance shall include compliance with the following specific rules:

1. No student shall knowingly, without authorization, procure, provide, or accept any materials which contain questions or answers to any examination or assignment.
2. No student shall, without authorization, complete, in part or in total, any examination or assignment for another person.
3. No student shall, without authorization, allow any examination or assignment to be completed, in part or in total, by another person.
4. No student shall knowingly plagiarize or copy the work of another person and submit it as his or her own.
5. No student shall submit work that has been previously graded or is being submitted concurrently to more than one course without authorization from the instructor(s) of the class(es) to which the student wishes to submit it.

2.2.6.2 Plagiarism

Any ideas or material taken from another source for either written or oral presentation must be fully acknowledged. Offering the work of someone else as one's own is plagiarism. The language or ideas taken from another may range from isolated formulas, sentences, or paragraphs to entire articles copied from books, periodicals, speeches, or the writing of other students. The offering of materials assembled or collected by others in the form of projects or collections without acknowledgment also is considered plagiarism. Any student who fails to give credit in written or oral work for the ideas or materials that have been taken from another is guilty of plagiarism.

Such activity may result in failure of a specific assignment, an entire course, or, if flagrant, dismissal from Grand Valley. For further information see Student Rights and Responsibilities.

2.2.7 Communication and Technology Use

2.2.7.1 Technology Requirements for Online/Hybrid Courses

Although this class face-to-face, there is always the possibility that we may have to move online (synchronous). Thus, GVSU's [Technology Requirements for Online/Hybrid Courses](#) apply.

2.2.7.2 BlackBoard

Materials and information for this course will be posted to the course [BlackBoard](#) page. If you do not have access to the student network or need help in using BlackBoard, please let me know as soon as possible.

2.2.7.3 E-mail

Please check that the e-mail associated with your BlackBoard account is one that you check, as I will use that e-mail to send messages to the entire class.

2.2.7.4 WeBWorK

Practice problems will be available to you via the [WeBWorK](#) homework system. You are encouraged to make use of WeBWorK to practice and check your understanding. Although the feedback from WeBWorK is not as detailed as that from the instructor, it has the advantage of being essentially instantaneous!

2.2.7.5 Computer Algebra Systems

We will often make use of [Desmos Graphing Calculator](#) and [Amplify](#).

We will also sometimes use iPython interactive notebooks (such as [Google Colaboratory](#)). It is an interface to the python programming language, but *you are not expected to learn to program*.

2.2.7.6 Mathematical Typesetting

All material submitted for your portfolio is expected to be written using using the software capable of high-quality mathematical typesetting.

Options for mathematical typesetting include markdown notebooks, such as [Google Colab](#) or [Jupyter](#) Notebooks, or [Google Docs](#).

2.2.7.7 Recording of Classes

In the event that we meet virtually via Zoom, class meetings will be recorded and will be available to students enrolled in this course as a study aid. Students who do not want their likeness during class participation included in the recorded class session may elect to turn off the camera and change their name in the Zoom window. Recordings will be available for viewing subject to the following:

- Only students enrolled in the class may view the recording.
- Students may not post or use the recordings in any other setting (e.g., social media) for any purpose. Students who violate this will be subject to student discipline, up to and including expulsion.
- If faculty have any plan to use the recording for a different class in the future, the faculty member will need written FERPA consent from those students in the current class who are identifiable in any of the recordings. A FERPA consent form signed by all students in the course will also be needed if the recordings are made available to others beyond the classroom on a non-secure digital platform.

Chapter 3

Course Notes

The following notes are intended to remind you what we covered each week. They are not a substitute for attending class and not a substitute for reading the textbook.

3.1 Week 1

3.1.1 Tuesday, Sept. 1

Introduction, highlights from the syllabus, and an introduction to vectors using “Turtle Graphics” in a [Google Colaboratory Worksheet](#).

3.1.1.1 Main Ideas

The main take-away ideas from the introduction to vectors were:

- Vectors describe quantities that have not only a **magnitude**, or size, but also a **direction**.
- Vectors are often represented graphically using arrows, with a **tail**, where the vector starts, and a **head**, where the vector ends.
- A vector can be interpreted as a change, and graphically, only the direction and size, not the specific location, of a vector is important. So, for example, an arrow from $(0, 0)$ to $(30, -60)$ and an arrow from $(-10, 30)$ to $(20, -30)$ are different representation of the exact same vector, because in each case the x -coordinate changes by $+30$ and the y -coordinate changes by -60 .
- Two ways to represent vectors algebraically are using **angle brackets**, such as $\langle 30, -60 \rangle$, with the **elements** of the vector listed horizontally, and using **square brackets**, such as $\begin{bmatrix} 30 \\ -60 \end{bmatrix}$, with the elements listed vertically.
- Because the angle bracket and square bracket representations of vectors take a lot of space, we will often “name” vectors by assigning them to a variable, usually written either as a bold letter or an italic letter with an arrow over it. So, we might say something like “let $\vec{v} = \langle 30, -60 \rangle$ and let $\vec{w} = \langle 20, 20 \rangle$.”
- Vectors can be combined by *adding* them. Writing $\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$ indicates that if we add $\vec{v}$ and $\vec{w}$ the **resultant vector** is $\vec{u}$. Graphically, to find $\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$ when we are given $\vec{v}$ and $\vec{w}$, we place the tail of $\vec{w}$ at the head of $\vec{v}$, and $\vec{u}$ is the vector from the tail of $\vec{v}$ to the head of $\vec{w}$. (See example below.)

Example 4 Addition of Vectors. Let $\vec{v} = \langle 30, -60 \rangle$ and let $\vec{w} = \langle 20, 20 \rangle$. Let $\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$. We will represent the addition of $\vec{v}$ and $\vec{w}$ graphically and algebraically.

To add $\vec{v}$ and $\vec{w}$ graphically, since we have no information about where the tail of $\vec{v}$ should go, we will draw $\vec{v}$ with its tail at the origin (and so its head is at $(30, -60)$). Then, we draw $\vec{w}$ with its tail at the head of $\vec{v}$. Then, the vector $\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$ will have its tail at the tail of $\vec{v}$ and its head at the head of $\vec{w}$. So, for this example, the tail of $\vec{u}$ is at the origin and the head of $\vec{u}$ is at $(50, -40)$. **Note:** We have included a grid and tick marks on the graph, but they are not necessary. You can add vectors graphically without knowing their algebraic values!



Figure 5 Graphical Addition of Vectors

To add $\vec{v}$ and $\vec{w}$ algebraically, we add *element-wise*, which means we add according to position. We will show this using both angle brackets and square brackets.

$$\begin{aligned}
 \vec{u} &= \vec{v} + \vec{w} \\
 &= \langle 30, -60 \rangle + \langle 20, 20 \rangle \\
 &= \langle 30 + 20, -60 + 20 \rangle \\
 &= \langle 50, -40 \rangle
 \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \vec{u} &= \vec{v} + \vec{w} \\
 &= \begin{bmatrix} 30 \\ -60 \end{bmatrix} + \begin{bmatrix} 20 \\ 20 \end{bmatrix} \\
 &= \begin{bmatrix} 30 + 20 \\ -60 + 20 \end{bmatrix} \\
 &= \begin{bmatrix} 50 \\ -40 \end{bmatrix}
 \end{aligned}$$

Example 6 Graphical Addition of Vectors Without Coordinates. In Figure 5, we show how to add two vectors graphically without knowing the algebraic representations. ▲

To add $\vec{v}$ and $\vec{w}$ graphically, we draw $\vec{w}$ with its tail at the head of $\vec{v}$. Then, the vector $\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$ will have its tail at the tail of $\vec{v}$ and its head at the head of $\vec{w}$.



Figure 7 Graphical Addition of Vectors Without Coordinates

To add $\vec{v}$ and $\vec{w}$ algebraically, we add *element-wise*, which means we add according to position. We will show this using both angle brackets and square brackets.

$$\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$$

$$= \langle 30, -60 \rangle + \langle 20, 20 \rangle$$

$$= \langle 30 + 20, -60 + 20 \rangle$$

$$= \langle 50, -40 \rangle$$

$$\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$$

$$= \begin{bmatrix} 30 \\ -60 \end{bmatrix} + \begin{bmatrix} 20 \\ 20 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$= \begin{bmatrix} 30 + 20 \\ -60 + 20 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$= \begin{bmatrix} 50 \\ -40 \end{bmatrix}$$



3.1.1.2 Extensions

While we have looked at vectors in two dimensions, in the xy -plane, there are also three dimensional vectors that behave in pretty much the exact same way! Depending on how the semester goes, we may briefly take a look at three-dimensional vectors.

There are lots of things that can be treated as vectors. Mathematicians define what it means to be a vector not so much in terms of what something *is*, but more in terms of how it *behaves*, but we won't get that in this class.

Another thing to be aware of is that sometimes we want to graphically add vectors that are not drawn tail-to-head. For example, we might wish to add two vectors that are currently drawn with their tails in the same place. (This is common for

forces acting on a body in physics applications.)

Example 8 Two Forces Acting on a Body.. Figure 9 shows two forces, represented by $\vec{F}_1$ and $\vec{F}_2$ acting on a body (represented as a rectangle).

To add the vectors, we duplicate $\vec{F}_2$ with its tail at the head of $\vec{F}_1$ and we duplicate $\vec{F}_1$ with its tail at the head of $\vec{F}_2$, as shown by the dashed vectors. While we really only need to duplicate one of these, duplicating both allows us to see that the resultant vector, $\vec{F}_r = \vec{F}_1 + \vec{F}_2$, lies along the diagonal of a parallelogram.

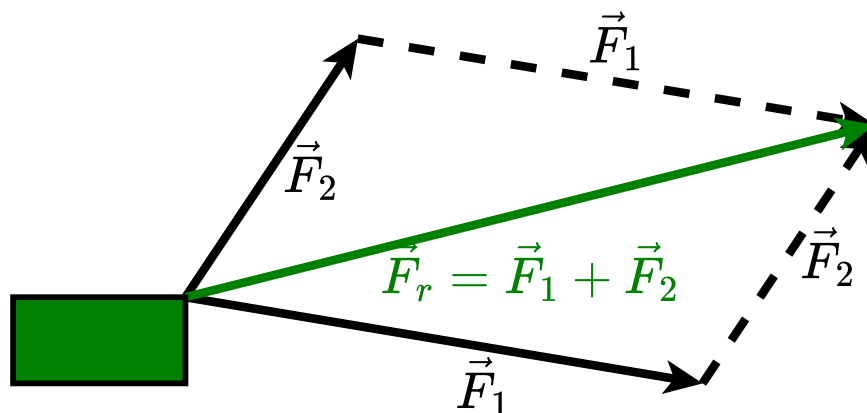


Figure 9 Showing $\vec{F}_r = \vec{F}_1 + \vec{F}_2$ where the tails of $\vec{F}_1$ and $\vec{F}_2$ coincide.

▲

3.1.2 Thursday, Sept. 3

Discussion of measures of success, very brief launch of ideas that lead to circular functions.

We will re-launch “Ferris Wheels and Circular Functions” on Tuesday.

Chapter 4

In-Class Activities

4.1 Ferris Wheels, Angles, and Distances

4.1.1 Height of a Ferris Wheel Car

Figure 10 shows the height of a Ferris wheel car as a function of the distance the car has travelled from the bottom. A full animation is available from the National Council of Teachers of Mathematics [NCTM] *Illustrations* classroom resources, [Investigating Functions with a Ferris Wheel: Distance vs. Height](http://gvsu.edu/s/3MV) (gvsu.edu/s/3MV).

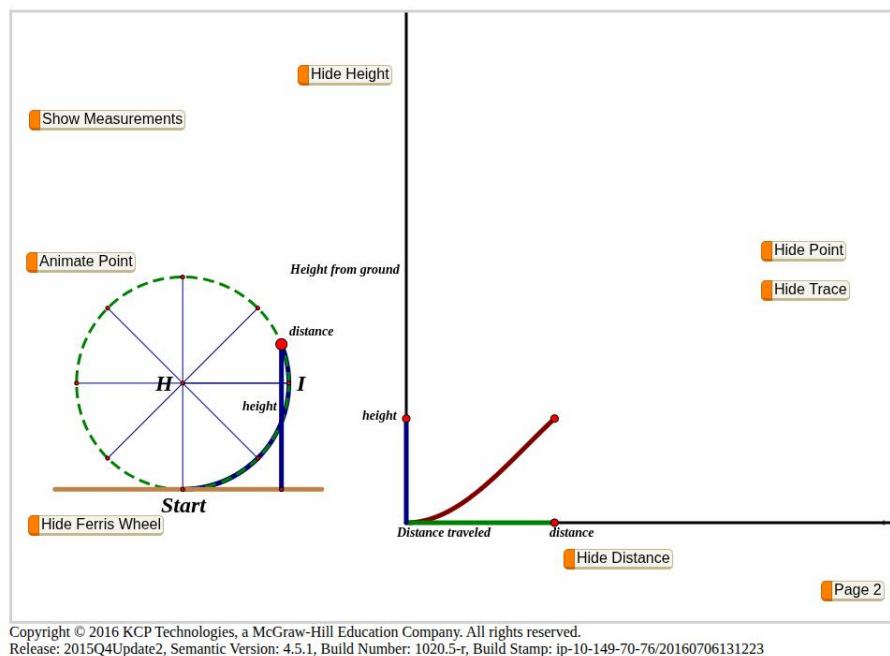


Figure 10 Height of a Ferris Wheel Car

- For the calculations in this exercise, assume that the circumference of the Ferris wheel is 128m, and recall that the circumference, C , of a circle is given by $C = 2\pi r$, where r is the radius of the circle.

We will refer to the height as h and the distance travelled as d .

- Find the total height of the Ferris wheel (in meters).

Answer. 40.74367m

Solution. The total height is twice the radius. Since the radius is $\frac{128\text{m}}{2\pi}$, the total height is $\frac{128\text{m}}{\pi} \approx 40.74367\text{m}$.

- When $d = 32\text{m}$, find the value of h . That is, when the car when has travelled 32m, how high is it?

Answer. 20.37183m

Solution. When the car has travelled 32m, it has travelled one quarter of the way around, or half-way to the top. Thus its height is half the total height, approximately 20.37183m.

- Find h when $d = 64\text{m}$.

Answer. 40.74367m

Solution. When the car has travelled 64m, it has travelled half of the way around, so it is at the top. Thus its height is the same as the total height, approximately 40.7467m.

- How much distance along the circle has the cab traversed at the moment it first reaches a height of $\frac{128\text{m}}{2\pi} \approx 20.37183\text{m}$?

Answer. 32m.

Solution. We know that $\frac{128\text{m}}{2\pi}$ is the radius, which is also half the diameter, and so the height is half of the total height. The first time the car reaches this height is when it has travelled $\frac{1}{4}$ of the way around, which is $\frac{128\text{m}}{4} = 32\text{m}$.

- (e) How much distance along the circle has the cab traversed at the moment it reaches a height of $\frac{128\text{m}}{2\pi} \approx 20.37183\text{m}$ for the *second* time?

Answer. 96m.

Solution. The second time the car reaches a height of is when it has travelled $\frac{3}{4}$ of the way around, which is $\frac{3}{4}128\text{m} = 96\text{m}$.

- (f) Can we express h as a function of d ?

Answer. Yes.

Solution. Every distance travelled corresponds to exactly one position on the circular path of the Ferris wheel car, and each position has a particular height. Since there is always exactly one value of h for each value of d , we can express h as a function of d .

- (g) Can we express d as a function of h ?

Answer. No.

Solution. As the Ferris wheel car travels around its circular path, it passes through each height multiple times. Since there is *not* always exactly one value of d for each value of h , we cannot express d as a function of h .

An important idea in setting up mathematical models that is often assumed or overlooked is the fact that *you get to choose where you measure from*. Sometimes the choice of your “reference point” is the difference between straight-forward calculations and much more complicated ones. With that in mind, we will revisit the Ferris wheel problem, but with a couple of slight twists.

First, instead of measuring height above the ground, we will measure the height, h , as the vertical distance from a horizontal line *through the center* of the Ferris wheel. Of course, we will need to indicate whether a given height is *above* the center or *below* the center, so we will use *positive* values of h to indicate distance *above* the center line, and *negative* values to indicate distance *below* the center line.

Second, we will measure the distance the Ferris wheel car has travelled relative to the point where it is farthest to the right. In other words, when it is on the center line.

Here, distances that are *before* reaching the line will be negative, and distances after will be positive.

2. For this problem, we will consider a Ferris wheel whose total height is 40m.

Recall that we are measuring distance travelled, d , relative to the point on the circle to the extreme right, and we are measuring the height, h , relative to the center of the Ferris wheel, so, for example, when $d = 0\text{m}$, $h = 0\text{m}$.

- (a) How high is the center of the Ferris wheel above the ground?

Answer. 20m.

Solution. The total height is 40m, so the center is half that distance above the ground, which is 20m.

- (b) What is the circumference of the Ferris wheel?

Answer. $\approx 125.6637\text{m}$.

Solution. We will call the radius of the Ferris wheel r and the circumference C . Since the total height is twice the radius, we have $r = 20\text{m}$, and thus $C = 2\pi r = 2\pi \cdot 20\text{m} \approx 125.6637\text{m}$.

- (c) What is the value of h when 31.4159m?

Answer. 20m.

Solution. When the car has travelled $31.4159\text{m} = \frac{1}{4} \cdot 125.6637\text{m}$, it has travelled $\frac{1}{4}$ of the circumference. Because we are measuring d from the point on the extreme right, this means that the Ferris wheel car is at its highest point. Since we are measuring h from the center of the Ferris wheel, that means that $h = 20\text{m}$.

- (d) What is the value of h when $d = 62.8315\text{m}$?

Answer. 0m.

Solution. When the car has travelled $62.8315\text{m} = \frac{1}{2} \cdot 125.6637\text{m}$, it has travelled $\frac{1}{2}$ of the circumference. Because we are measuring d from the point on the extreme right, this means that the Ferris wheel car is

at the extreme left. Since we are measuring h from the center of the Ferris wheel and we are back at the original height, that means that $h = 0\text{m}$.

- (e) What is the value of h when $d = 94.2478\text{m}$?

Answer. -20m .

Solution. When the car has travelled $94.2478\text{m} = \frac{3}{4} \cdot 125.6637\text{m}$, it has travelled $\frac{3}{4}$ of the circumference. Because we are measuring d from the point on the extreme right, this means that the Ferris wheel car is at the bottom of its path, so it is 20m below the center, and therefore $h = -20\text{m}$.

4.1.2 Distance and Angles

In [Worksheet Exercise 4.1.1.2](#), we know that the Ferris wheel is 40m tall, so it has a radius of 20m. We also know that the circumference is $C = 2\pi r \approx 125.6637\text{m}$. Said another way, the radius would fit $2\pi \approx 6.28$ times around the circle. Given two points on a circle, the part of the circle between them is called an **arc**, and its length is, appropriately, called the **arc length**. So, there are 2π radii of arc length in a circle.

It's not too much of a stretch to wonder how many radii of arc length lie between two points on a circle, and in fact, it gives a very natural way to measure angles, because given any angle, the arc length determined by the angle depends on the radius of the circle, and if an angle has an arc length of one radius on one circle, that same angle has one radius of arc length on any circle!

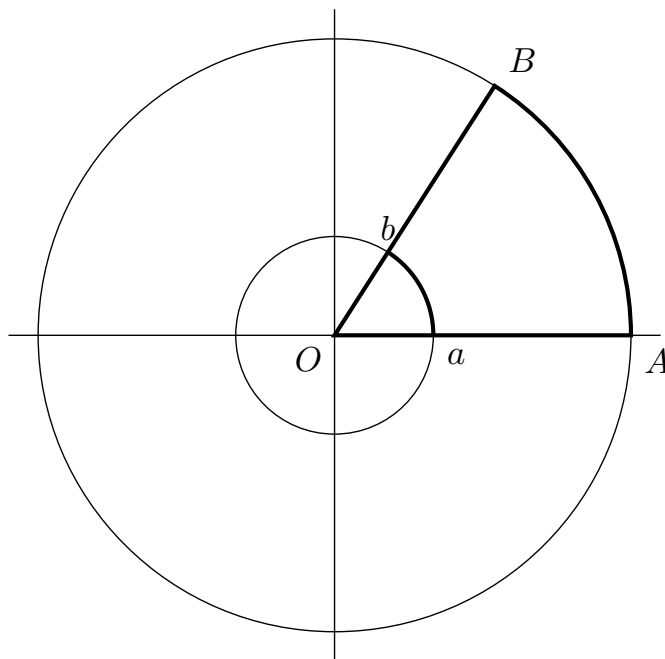


Figure 11 One radius of arc length on two different circles

An angle that has one radius of arc length has a measure of 1 **radian**. Both of the angles shown in [Figure 11](#), $\angle AOB$ and $\angle aOb$, have a measure of 1 radian, which we will often abbreviate as 1 rad.

1. In this problem, we again consider a circle (a Ferris wheel) with a radius of 20m.
 - (a) When the car has travelled through 1 rad of angle, how much distance (arc length) has it travelled?

Answer. 20m

Solution. When the car has travelled one radian, it has travelled a distance (arc length) equal to its radius. Since the radius is 20m, the car has travelled 20m.

- (b) When the car has travelled through an angle of 2.5 rad, how much arc length has it travelled?

Answer. 50m.

Solution. When the car has travelled 2.5 rad, it has travelled an arc length that is 2.5 times its radius, so it has travelled an arc length of $2.5 \cdot 20\text{m} = 50\text{m}$.

- (c) When the car has travelled through 30m of arc length, what angle (in radians) has it travelled through?

Answer. 1.5 rad.

Solution. When the car has travelled through θ rad, it has travelled a distance of $\theta \cdot 20\text{m}$, so we can solve $20\text{m} \cdot \theta = 30\text{m}$ to get $\theta = \frac{30\text{m}}{20\text{m}} = 1.5 \text{ rad}$.²

- (d) What is the arc length of one quarter of the circle?

Answer. 31.4159m

Solution. The total circumference is $2\pi \cdot 20\text{m} = 40\pi\text{m} \approx 125.6637\text{m}$, so one quarter of the circumference is $40\pi\text{m}/4 = 10\pi \approx 31.4159\text{m}$.

- (e) What is the radian measure of one quarter of a revolution (the angle for one fourth of a circle)?

Answer. $\pi/2 \approx 1.57079$ rad.

Solution. There are two ways we could approach this. We could use our previous result for the arc length of a quarter circle is approximately 31.4159m and divide by the radius to find the angle,

$$\frac{31.4159\text{m}}{20\text{m}} \approx 1.57079$$

or we could realize that there are 2π radii in the circumference, and thus a total revolution is 2π radians. Then, we get that one quarter of that is $\frac{2\pi}{4} = \frac{\pi}{2} \approx 1.57079$ radians.

- (f) What is the radian measure of one eighth of a revolution?

Answer. $\pi/4 \approx 0.78534$ rad.

Solution. Since there are 2π radii in the circumference, and thus a total revolution is 2π rad, we get that one eighth of that is $\frac{2\pi}{8} = \frac{\pi}{4} \approx 0.78534$ rad.

- (g) What fraction of the distance around the circle is $\frac{\pi}{4}$ rad?

Answer. One eighth.

A couple of important things about radians before we move on.

- As we noted in the solution to [Task 4.1.2.1.c](#), radians are **unitless** from a dimensional/unit analysis point of view.
- One full revolution, what we are used to thinking of as 360° , is 2π rad. This means that $180^\circ = \pi$ rad, and a right angle is $90^\circ = \frac{\pi}{2}$ rad. In general, the conversions between degrees and radians are

$$d \text{ deg} = \frac{\pi}{180} d \text{ rad}, \quad \theta \text{ rad} = \theta \left(\frac{180}{\pi} \right) \text{ deg}.$$

- Some important angles to become familiar with are:

$\frac{\pi}{6} = 30^\circ,$	$\frac{\pi}{4} = 45^\circ,$	$\frac{\pi}{3} = 60^\circ,$	$\frac{\pi}{2} = 90^\circ,$
$\frac{2\pi}{3} = 120^\circ,$	$\frac{3\pi}{4} = 135^\circ,$	$\frac{5\pi}{6} = 150^\circ,$	$\pi = 180^\circ,$
$\frac{7\pi}{6} = 210^\circ,$	$\frac{5\pi}{4} = 225^\circ,$	$\frac{4\pi}{3} = 240^\circ,$	$\frac{3\pi}{2} = 270^\circ,$
$\frac{5\pi}{3} = 300^\circ,$	$\frac{7\pi}{4} = 315^\circ,$	$\frac{11\pi}{6} = 330^\circ,$	$2\pi = 360^\circ.$

²It is worth noting here that if we do unit analysis of $20\text{m}/30\text{m}$, we see that the units cancel out. Therefore, technically radians are **unitless**.

4.1.3 The Sine and Cosine Functions

Probably the two most important functions in trigonometry are defined based on angles and the coordinates of points on a circle of radius 1, which we refer to as **the unit circle**.

For any point, P , on the unit circle, we measure the angle for P *in radians* from the positive x -axis counter-clockwise to P . Negative angles and angles greater than 2π are allowed: negative angles are measured counter-clockwise from the positive x -axis, and angles greater than 2π (or less than -2π) start around the circle again.

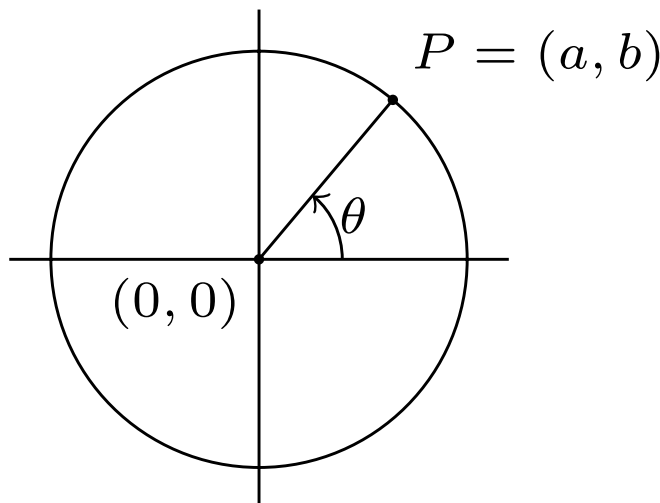


Figure 12 The Unit Circle with an Angle Shown

Figure 12 shows the unit circle with a point $P = (a, b)$ and its angle, θ .

Now that we have the unit circle and have explained how we measure angles on the unit circle, we are ready to define the circular functions **sine** and **cosine**.

Definition 13 The Sine and Cosine Functions. For any real number θ , define the point $P = (a, b)$ on the unit circle whose angle (measured from the positive x -axis) is θ rad. Then the cosine of θ is the x -coordinate of P and the sine of θ is the y -coordinate of P . That is,

$$\cos(\theta) = a,$$

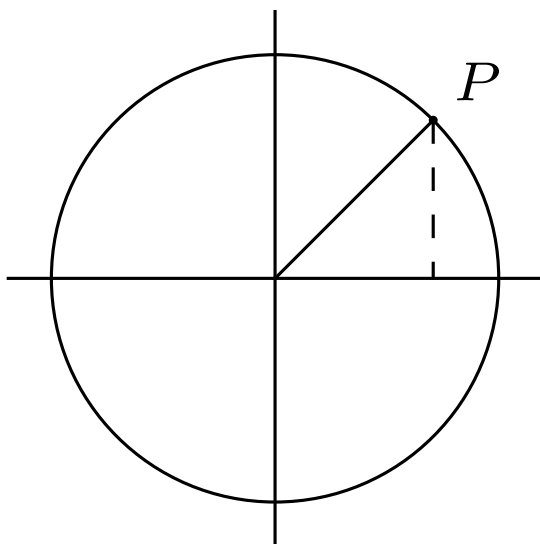
$$\sin(\theta) = b.$$

◆

Example 14 We will find $\sin\left(\frac{\pi}{4}\right)$ and $\cos\left(\frac{\pi}{4}\right)$.

We know that $\frac{\pi}{4}$ is 45° , so we start by drawing a point on the unit circle that makes an angle of $\frac{\pi}{4}$ with the positive x -axis and drop a perpendicular from the point to the x -axis.

Because we now have a 45, 45, 90 triangle, we know the x - and y -coordinates of P will be the same size, and because we are in the first quadrant, they will both be positive. So, let $P = (a, a)$, where $a > 0$, and we will find the value of a , and therefore the sine and cosine of $\frac{\pi}{4}$.



From the Pythagorean theorem, since the unit circle has radius 1 and the radius of the unit circle is the hypotenuse of the right triangle, we have

$$a^2 + a^2 = 1^2$$

so

$$2a^2 = 1.$$

Dividing by 2 gives us

$$a^2 = \frac{1}{2},$$

and then taking the (positive) square root give us

$$\begin{aligned} a &= \sqrt{\frac{1}{2}} \\ &= \frac{\sqrt{1}}{\sqrt{2}} \\ &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}. \end{aligned}$$

If we want to rationalize the denominator, we can multiply both the numerator and denominator by $\sqrt{2}$ to get

$$\begin{aligned} a &= \frac{1 \cdot \sqrt{2}}{\sqrt{2} \cdot \sqrt{2}} \\ &= \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}. \end{aligned}$$

Therefore, we now know that $\cos\left(\frac{\pi}{4}\right) = \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$ and $\sin\left(\frac{\pi}{4}\right) = \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$. ▲

1. In the following explorations, use symmetry, the Pythagorean theorem, and geometry to relate angles and the values of sine and cosine.

One geometry fact you may not know is the following: in a triangle with angles $\frac{\pi}{6} = 30^\circ$, $\frac{\pi}{3} = 60^\circ$, and $\frac{\pi}{2} = 90^\circ$ (a 30-60-90 triangle), the shortest side (opposite the $30^\circ = \frac{\pi}{6}$ angle) is half the length of the hypotenuse (longest side).

- (a) Find $\sin\left(\frac{\pi}{6}\right)$ and $\cos\left(\frac{\pi}{6}\right)$.

Answer.

$$\begin{aligned} \sin\left(\frac{\pi}{6}\right) &= \frac{1}{2} \\ \cos\left(\frac{\pi}{6}\right) &= \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} \end{aligned}$$

Solution. Dropping a perpendicular from the point at $\frac{\pi}{6}$ on the unit circle creates a 30-60-90 triangle with the perpendicular being the shortest side. Since the hypotenuse has length 1, that means that the y -coordinate of the point is $\frac{1}{2}$, and so $\sin\left(\frac{\pi}{6}\right) = \frac{1}{2}$. Then, from the Pythagorean theorem, if we let the x -coordinate of the point be a , we have

$$a^2 + \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^2 = 1^2$$

so

$$a^2 + \frac{1}{4} = 1$$

and therefore $a^2 = \frac{3}{4}$. Since we know that $a > 0$, we know that $a = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$. Thus, $\cos\left(\frac{\pi}{6}\right) = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$.

- (b) Find $\sin\left(\frac{\pi}{3}\right)$ and $\cos\left(\frac{\pi}{3}\right)$.

Hint. Use symmetry and the previous problem.

Answer.

$$\begin{aligned}\sin\left(\frac{\pi}{3}\right) &= \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} \\ \cos\left(\frac{\pi}{3}\right) &= \frac{1}{2}\end{aligned}$$

- (c) Find $\sin\left(\frac{5\pi}{6}\right)$ and $\cos\left(\frac{5\pi}{6}\right)$.

Answer.

$$\begin{aligned}\sin\left(\frac{5\pi}{6}\right) &= \frac{1}{2} \\ \cos\left(\frac{5\pi}{6}\right) &= \frac{-\sqrt{3}}{2}\end{aligned}$$

Solution. Dropping a perpendicular from the point at $\frac{5\pi}{6}$ on the unit circle creates a 30-60-90 triangle with the perpendicular being the shortest side. Since the hypotenuse has length 1, that means that the y -coordinate of the point is $\frac{1}{2}$, and so $\sin\left(\frac{5\pi}{6}\right) = \frac{1}{2}$. Then, from the Pythagorean theorem, if we let the x -coordinate of the point be a , we have

$$a^2 + \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^2 = 1^2$$

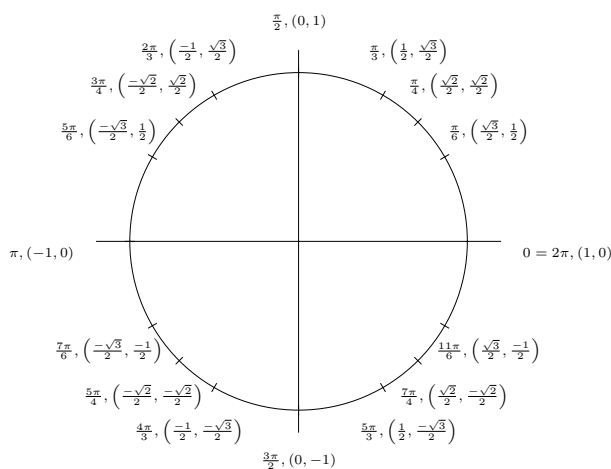
so

$$a^2 + \frac{1}{4} = 1$$

and therefore $a^2 = \frac{3}{4}$. Since the point is in the second quadrant, we know that $a < 0$, so we know that $a = \frac{-\sqrt{3}}{2}$. Thus, $\cos\left(\frac{5\pi}{6}\right) = \frac{-\sqrt{3}}{2}$.

- (d) Use symmetry to find the coordinates of each of the points at the important angles shown in Figure 15.

Answer.



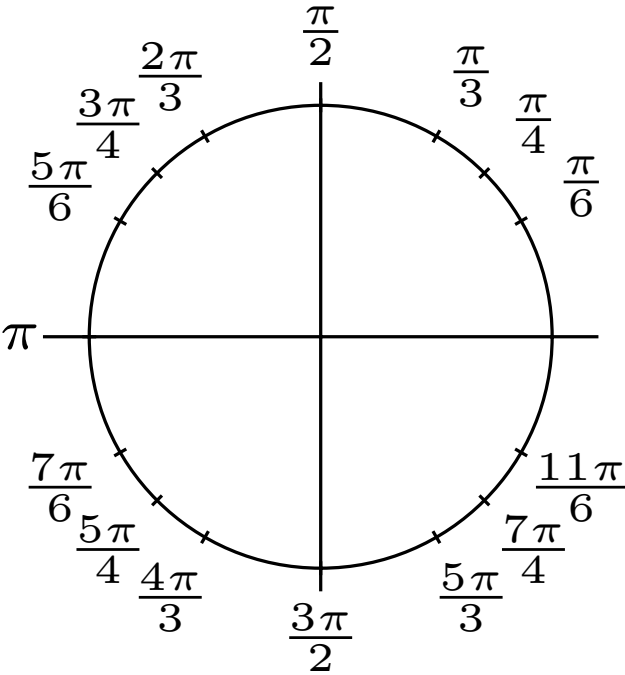


Figure 15 The Unit Circle with Important Angles

4.1.4 Similar Triangles and the Pythagorean Theorem

An extremely important concept in physics, trigonometry, calculus, and even carpentry is the notion of *similar triangles*. We will briefly discuss how to recognize similar triangles and what properties they have before returning to the ideas we explored in [Worksheet 4.1.1](#).

Combining the definitions of sine and cosine with similar triangles and the Pythagorean theorem gives us tools that make these functions extremely useful in a variety of situations.

Definition 16 Similar Triangles. When two triangles have exactly the same three angles, we say that they are *similar triangles* or that the triangles are *similar*. ♦

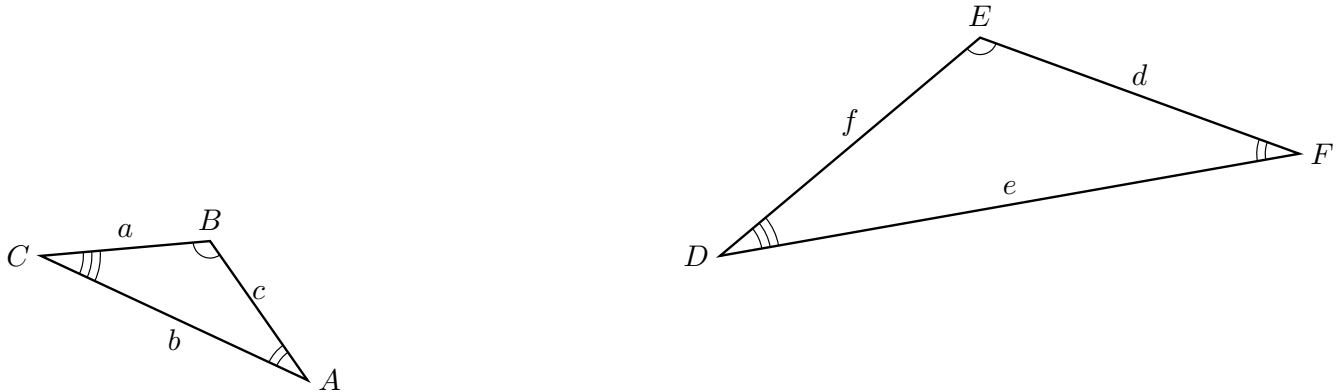


Figure 17 An Example of Similar Triangles

The triangles shown in [Figure 17](#) are similar because angle C is the same as angle D ($\angle C \cong \angle D$), angle B is the same as angle E ($\angle B \cong \angle E$), and angle A is the same as angle F ($\angle A \cong \angle F$).

We say that $\angle C$ and $\angle D$, $\angle B$ and $\angle E$, $\angle A$ and $\angle F$ are *corresponding angles*, and similarly, we say that sides $\overline{CB}$ and $\overline{DE}$, sides $\overline{BA}$ and $\overline{EF}$, sides $\overline{AC}$ and $\overline{FD}$ are *corresponding sides*.

Furthermore, we say that $\triangle CBA \sim \triangle DEF$, and the order matters!

Theorem 18 Corresponding Sides of Similar Triangles. Given two triangles, $\triangle MNE$ and $\triangle PQR$, when the triangles are similar ($\triangle MNE \sim \triangle PQR$), the lengths of the corresponding sides are proportional.

Applying [Theorem 18](#) to [Figure 17](#), for example, we have that

$$\frac{f}{a} = \frac{e}{b} = \frac{d}{c},$$

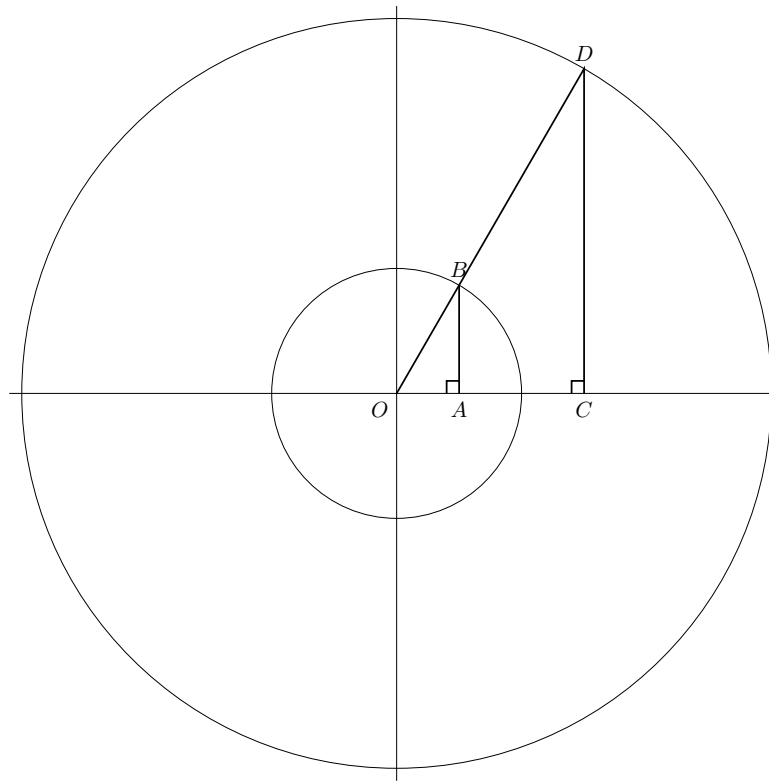
and, equivalently,

$$\frac{a}{c} = \frac{f}{d}, \quad \frac{a}{b} = \frac{f}{e}, \quad \frac{b}{c} = \frac{d}{e}.$$

Theorem 19 The Pythagorean Theorem. For any positive numbers, a , b , and c , if a and b are the lengths of two legs of a right triangle and c is the length of the hypotenuse, then $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$.

Furthermore, for any triangle with side lengths a , b , and c , if $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$, then the triangle is a right triangle, the sides with lengths a and b are the legs, and the side with length c is the hypotenuse.

1. In [Figure 20](#), $\overline{OA}$ has length 0.5m, $\overline{OB}$ has length 1m, and $\overline{OD}$ has length 3m.

**Figure 20** Circles with Similar Triangles

- (a) Explain why $\triangle OBA$ is similar to $\triangle ODC$.

Solution. Both triangles share $\angle AOB \cong \angle COD$, and $\angle DCO$ and $\angle BAO$ are both right angles. Because the measures of the three angles of any triangle add to $180^\circ = \pi$ radians, we must have $\angle OBA \cong \angle ODC$. Since all three angles of $\triangle OBA$ are congruent to the respective angles of $\triangle ODC$, the two triangles are similar, $\triangle OBA \sim \triangle ODC$.

- (b) Use the fact that $\triangle OBA \sim \triangle ODC$ to find the length of $\overline{OC}$.

Answer. 1.5m.

Solution. We will represent the length of a segment as the two endpoints, so, for example, we will say that $OA = 0.5\text{m}$.

We know that $OA = 0.5\text{m}$, $OB = 1\text{m}$, and $OD = 3\text{m}$.

Because $\triangle OBA \sim \triangle ODC$, we know that $\frac{OA}{OB} = \frac{OC}{OD}$, so substituting the known lengths, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{OC}{OD} &= \frac{OA}{OB} \rightarrow \frac{OC}{3\text{m}} = \frac{0.5\text{m}}{1\text{m}} \\ &\rightarrow OC = 3\text{m} \frac{0.5\text{m}}{1\text{m}} \\ &\rightarrow OC = 1.5\text{m} \end{aligned}$$

- (c) Use the Pythagorean theorem to find AB , the length of $\overline{AB}$.

Answer. $\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}\text{m} \approx 0.866025\text{m}$.

Solution. From the Pythagorean theorem, since $\triangle BAO$ is a right triangle, we have $(BA)^2 + (OA)^2 = (OB)^2$, so $(BA)^2 + (0.5)^2 = (1)^2$, so

$$\begin{aligned} (BA)^2 &= (1)^2 - (0.5)^2 \\ &= 1 - 0.25 \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned} &= 0.75 \\ &= \frac{3}{4} \end{aligned}$$

so

$$\begin{aligned} BA &= \sqrt{\frac{3}{4}} \\ &= \frac{\sqrt{3}}{\sqrt{4}} \\ &= \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} \\ &\approx 0.866025. \end{aligned}$$

(d) Find the length of CD .

Answer. $\frac{3\sqrt{3}}{2}\text{m} \approx 2.5981\text{m}$

4.2 Practical Applications of Sine and Cosine

Example 21 We will show how to use sine, cosine, and similar triangles to solve a practical problem.

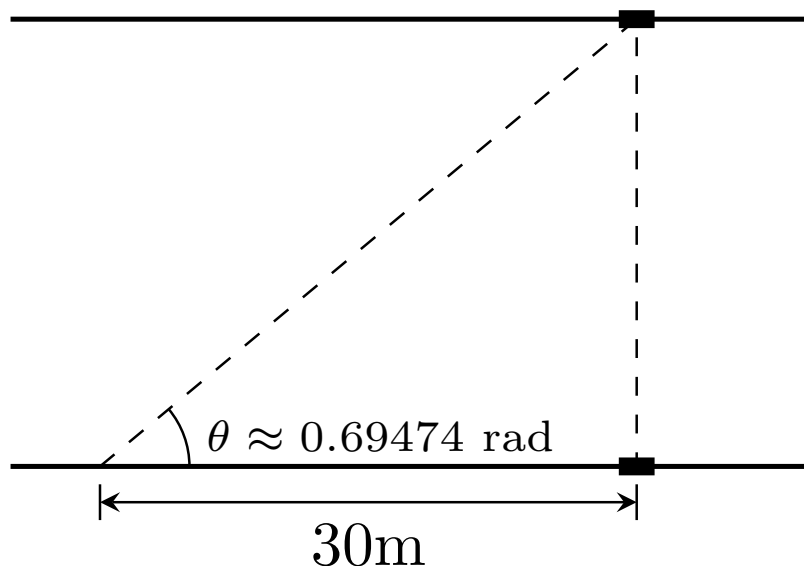


Figure 22 Two Gatehouses on a Canal Lock

Amir is standing at the edge of a canal lock. There are gatehouses on each side of the lock. The gatehouse on the same side as Amir is located 30m from them. Amir wants to find out how wide the lock is by finding how far one gatehouse is from the other. Amir measures the angle from the near gatehouse to the far gatehouse and finds that it is 0.69474 rad.

How wide is the lock?

We start by drawing a copy of the unit circle centered on Amir's position, and we will assign the distance between the two gatehouses to the variable d . Then, by dropping a perpendicular from the point, P , where the line from Amir to the far gatehouse crosses the circle, we have similar triangles.

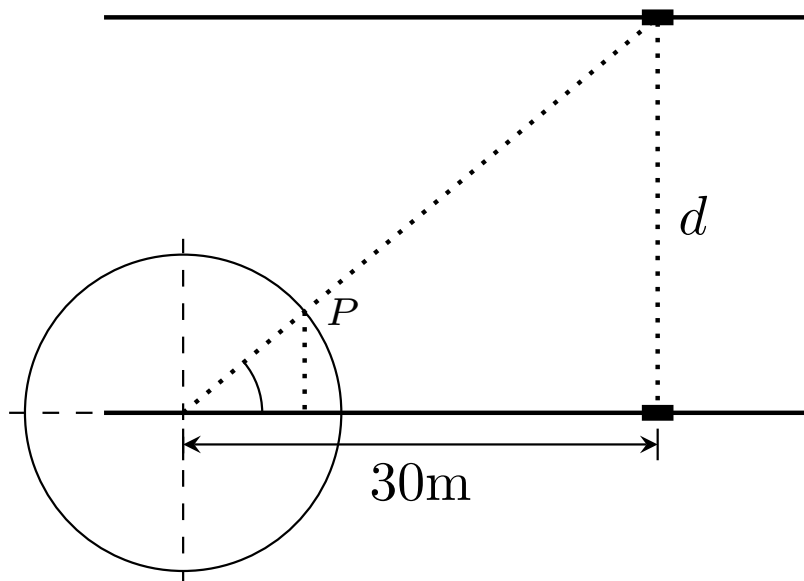


Figure 23 Canal Lock with Unit Circle

We know that P has coordinates $(\cos(0.69474), \sin(0.69474))$ (which we will leave unevaluated until the end). Furthermore, we know from similar triangles that corresponding parts are proportional, so we have

$$\frac{d}{\sin(0.69474)} = \frac{30\text{m}}{\cos(0.69474)}.$$

Multiplying both sides by $\sin(0.69474)$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} d &= \frac{30\text{m} \sin(0.69474)}{\cos(0.69474)} \\ &\approx 25\text{m} \end{aligned}$$



1. Inaya wants to use trigonometry to measure the height of a tree. She walks 10m away from the base of the tree and measures the angle to the top of the tree as shown in Figure 24.

To the nearest tenth of a meter, how tall is the tree? That is, what is the value of d in meters?

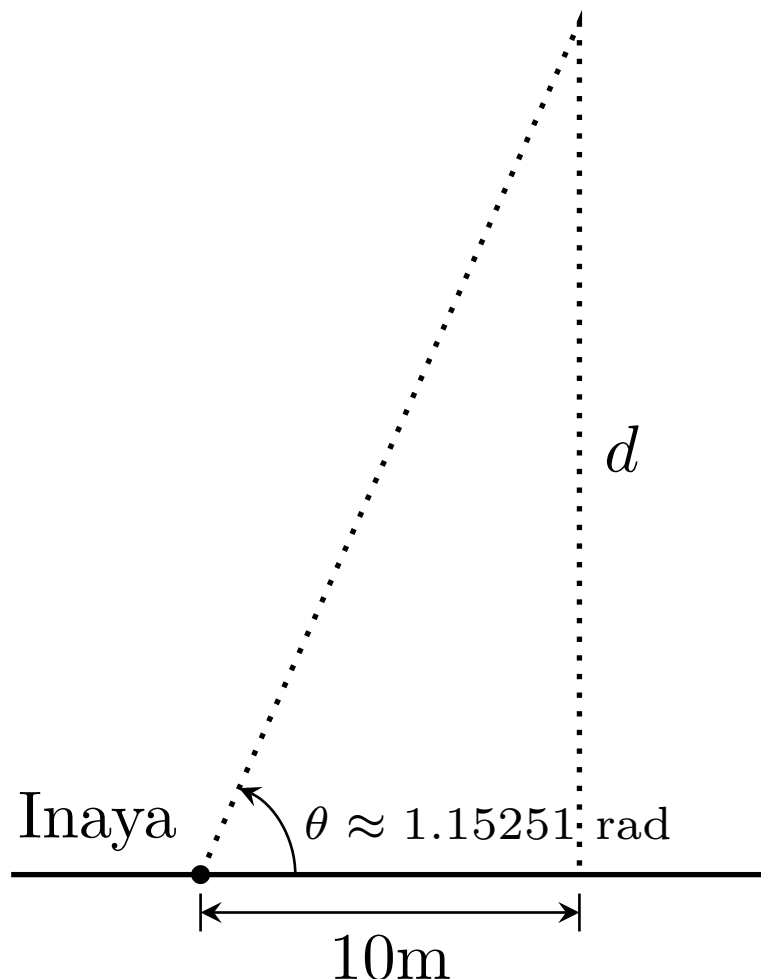


Figure 24 An Observer and a Tree

Answer. The tree is approximately 22.5m tall.

Solution. Draw a circle that represents the unit circle around the point representing Inaya and set your coordinate axes so that this is the origin.

Drop a perpendicular from where the circle intersects the line from Inaya to the top of the tree. We then have a small triangle with corners at the origin, on the unit circle, and on the x -axis. This triangle is similar to the triangle from the origin to the top of the tree to the x -axis because they share the angle θ and they both have right angles on the x -axis.

We know the coordinates of the point on the unit circle are $(\cos(\theta), \sin(\theta))$, and we know that the sides of the small triangle are proportional to the sides of the big triangle. Thus, $\frac{d}{10\text{m}} = \frac{\sin(\theta)}{\cos(\theta)}$, so we have

$$d = 10\text{m} \frac{\sin(\theta)}{\cos(\theta)}$$

$$\begin{aligned} &= 10\text{m} \frac{\sin(1.15251)}{\cos(1.15251)} \\ &= 22.5\text{m} \end{aligned}$$

2. Micah is watching a train as it approaches. He is 10m from the closest point on the track.

He observes that the train makes an angle of approximately 0.98273 radians, and then one second later an angle of approximately 0.89594 radians. How fast is the train travelling?

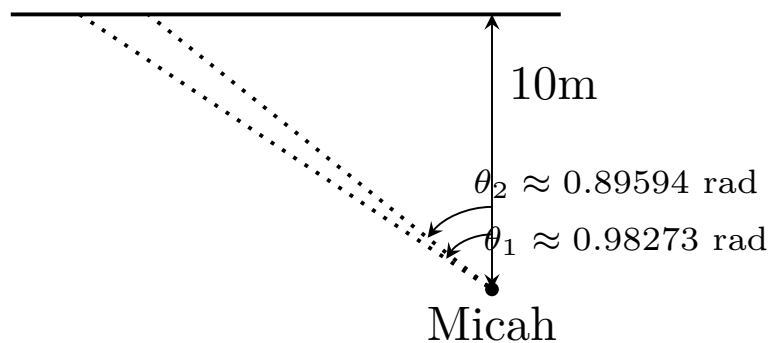


Figure 25 A Train on a Track